# Bhakti Movement

**SUFISM**

- It had its origin in Persia and spread into India in the eleventh century.

**Some Sufi Saints:-**

1. Shaikh Ismail of Lahore (First Sufi Saint)
2. Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti (Ajmer)

- **The first Sufi saint Shaikh Ismail** of Lahore started preaching his ideas.
- The most famous of the Sufi saints of India was **Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti**, who settled in Ajmer which became the centre of his activities. He had a number of disciples who are **called Sufis of the Chishti order**
- Bahauddin Zakariya came under the influence of another famous mystic, **Shihabuddin Suhrawardi.** His branch of Sufi saints was known as the Sufis of the **Suhrawardi Order.**

**CHARACTERISTIC FEATURES OF SUFISM :-**

- Love of God meant love of humanity and so the Sufis believed service to humanity was tantamount to service to God.
- The Sufis lay stress on inner purity.
- The Sufis consider love and devotion as the only means of attaining salvation.

**BHAKTI**

**MOVEMENT**

**SANKARA**

- In the ninth century Sankara gave a new orientation to Hinduism.
- Born in Kaladi in Kerala.
- His doctrine o**f Advaita or Monism** was too abstract to appeal to the common man.
- There was a reaction against the Advaita concept of **Nirgunabrahman (God without attributes**) with the emergence of the **idea of Sagunabrahman (God with attributes).**

**RAMANUJA**

- In the twelfth century, Ramanuja, who was born at Sriperumbudur near modern Chennai, preached **Visishtadvaita.**
- According to him God is **Saguna Brahman.** The creative process and all the objects in creation are **real but not illusory as was held by Sankaracharya.**
- Therefore, God, soul, matter are real. But God is the inner substance and the rest are his attributes.
- He also advocated prabattimarga or path of self-surrender to God.
- He invited the downtrodden to Vaishnavism

**MADHAVA**

- In the thirteenth century, Madhava from Kannada region propagated **Dvaita or dualism** of Jivatma and Paramatma.
- According to his philosophy, **the world is not an illusion but a reality.**

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**NIMBARKA and VALLABHACHARYA**

- Preachers of Vaishnavite Bhakti in the Telangana region.

**SURDAS**

- Disciple of Vallabhacharya and he popularized Krishna cult in north India.

**MIRABAI**

- Great devotee of Krishna she became popular in Rajasthan for her bhajans.

**TULSIDAS**

- Worshipper of Rama and composed the famous **Ramcharitmanas, the Hindi version of Ramayana.**

- In the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries, **Ramananda, Kabir and Nanak** remained great apostles of the Bhakti cult. They drew inspiration from old masters but showed a new path.
- They helped the common people to shed age-old superstitions and attain salvation through Bhakti or pure devotion.
- Unlike the early reformers, they were not linked with any particular religious creed

and did not believe in rituals and ceremonies.

- **They condemned polytheism and believed in one god.** They also denounced all forms of idolatry.
- They strongly believed in **Bhakti as the only means of salvation**. They also emphasised the fundamental unity of all religions.

**RAMANANDA**

- Born at Allahabad.
- Originally a **follower of Ramanuja** , later founded his own sect and preached his principles in Hindi at Banaras and Agra.
- He was a worshipper of Rama. He was the first to employ the vernacular medium to propagate his ideas.
- Simplification of worship and emancipation of people from the traditional caste rules were his two important contributions to the Bhakti movement.
- **He opposed the caste system** and chose his disciples from all sections of society disregarding caste.

**KABIR**

- Among the disciples of Ramananda the most famous was Kabir. He was born near Banaras.
- Kabir's object was **to reconcile Hindus and Muslims** and establish harmony between the two sects.
- He **denounced idolatry and rituals** and **laid great emphasis on the equality of man before God.**
- He emphasized the essential **oneness of all religions** by describing **Hindus and Muslims 'as pots of the same clay'.**
- He regarded devotion to god as an effective means of salvation and urged that to achieve this one must have a pure heart, free from cruelty, dishonesty, hypocrisy and insincerity.
- **His followers are called Kabirpanthis.**

**GURU NANAK**

- **Founder of the Sikh religion** and a disciple of Kabir. He was born in Talwandi near Lahore.

- He denounced caste distinctions and rituals like bathing in holy rivers.
- He exhorted people to give up selfishness, falsehood and hypocrisy and to lead a life of truth, honesty and kindness. 'Abide pure amidst the impurities of the world' was one of his famous sayings.

**CHAITANYA**

- Well-known saint and reformer of Bengal who popularised the Krishna cult. He proclaimed the universal brotherhood of man and condemned all distinctions based on religion and caste.
- He emphasized love and peace and showed great sympathy to the sufferings of other people, especially that of the poor and the weak.

**GNANADEVA** was the founder of the **Bhakti Movement in Maharashtra** in the thirteenth century. He **wrote a commentary on Bhagavad Gita called Gnaneswari.**

**NAMADEVA**

- preached the gospel of love. He opposed idol worship and priestly domination. He also opposed the caste system.

**EKANATHA** opposed caste distinctions and sympathetic towards the lower castes

**TUKARAM, a contemporary of King Shivaji.** He was responsible for creating a background for Maratha nationalism. He opposed all social distinctions.

**IMPORTANCE OF THE BHAKTI MOVEMENT**

- It provided an impetus for the development of regional languages such as Hindi, Marathi, Bengali, Kannada, etc. Through these languages they made direct appeal to the masses.
- As the caste system was condemned by the Bhakti saints, the lower classes were raised to a position of great importance.
- The importance of women in society was also increased because the Bhakti movement gave equal importance to them.
- The Bhakti movement gave to the people a simple religion, without complicated rituals. They were required to show sincere devotion to God.